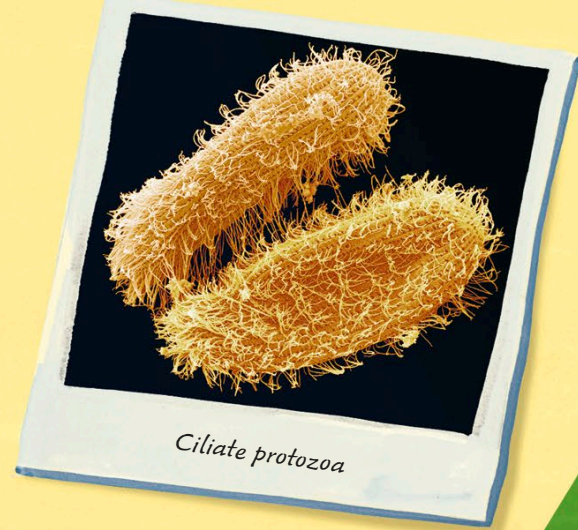




NETTIE STEVENS

American geneticist
1861–1912



Ciliate protozoa

The first creatures Nettie studied were protozoa, which are made up of just one cell.

From beetles to blue whales, most animals have two sexes: male and female. With two sexes, animals can take part in a process called reproduction. Female animals make special cells, called gametes, with half of the instructions needed for a new baby animal. Male animals make gametes that contain the other half of the instructions. When these two sets of instructions join together in an egg cell—in a process called fertilization—the cell starts to develop into a new baby animal.

But why do some eggs develop into female animals, while others develop into males? Is it because of the conditions they grow in, such as the temperature or food supply? Or is it something inside the cells themselves? Nettie Stevens was the first scientist to answer this question.



After protozoa, Nettie studied the gametes and fertilized eggs of mealworm beetles.

